Urjit Patel; and the role of the RBI board. The chapter also covers the infamous Demonetization Dividend and the frequent about-turns of policy that led to the RBI being called the 'Reverse Bank of India'. Issues such as the impact of this note ban on the reputation and credibility of bankers in general and the RBI in particular are analysed, with the benefit of the perspective of former Governors and Deputy Governors. This chapter also questions why, despite clear warnings, the custodian of the Indian currency and guardian of our country's monetary stability passively agreed to a step that extinguished 86.9 per cent of the Currency in Circulation, without any clear plan or preparation for remonetizing the system.

What makes this episode of demonetization interesting is that it was preceded by two earlier note bans, both of which failed in achieving the objectives of eliminating black money and corruption.

Chapter 3 takes a step back into history to look at the story and outcomes of India's previous demonetization experiments in 1946 and 1978. We also look at the history of similar unsuccessful demonetizations in countries across the world such as Ghana, Myanmar, the erstwhile Soviet Union and North Korea. However, in and of itself, demonetization is not a bad idea. It is merely a tool – well suited in certain specific circumstances, and most effective if planned meticulously and executed efficiently. There are also examples of successful demonetizations and the circumstances under which this policy measure is best used.

Chapter 4 describes the human impact of the note ban. With the passage of time, it is easy to view such policy measures through the prism of statistics, which disguise the misery, despair and desperation experienced by those who suffered its consequences. This chapter has extracts of stories of Indians from all walks of life and the devastation wreaked by demonetization on their lives. Though government spokespersons have dismissed such reports as 'anecdotal evidence', these stories are real and they matter. The picture they paint is one of a monumental catastrophe.